

MAIN CHARACTER SYNDROME

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EXT. ATLANTA HIGHWAY - DAY

HONK! Bumper to bumper traffic. Hundreds of frustrated drivers blast their horns in the summer heat.

As we see other drivers, we eventually pan to a BEAT UP RED CAR. Tapping his right hand against the wheel and holding his cellphone in his left is our hero, MASON GRANT.

Mason's a recent college grad with a head full of dreams and a useless degree. The happiness of his youth has been crushed by the burden of modern life.

In his left phone, the DOORDASH interface. In the passenger seat is a large paper bag for a delivery, stapled at top.

While looking at his phone, a honk from behind him.

ANGRY DRIVER

Look up from your fucking phone,
asshole!

Mason quickly looks up and sees that the cars have started moving. He puts the gas on for a second before the traffic starts again. He groans.

EXT. NEIGHBORHOOD STREET - EVENING

Mason SPEEDS down a street and slams on his breaks. He grabs the bag and runs out of the car.

Walking up to a nice house, Mason looks at the interface:
GUARANTEED PAY: \$5.45 + TIP HIDDEN UNTIL AFTER DELIVERY.
Mason crosses his fingers.

He knocks on the door and waits. A LARGE MAN, in his late 50s with a large beard answers the door.

LARGE MAN

(angrily)

Took you long enough! I could've
walked there and picked up the
order myself and avoided all those
fees.

MASON

Traffic is crazy, I don't know what
to tell you.

LARGE MAN

Is everything there?

Mason shrugs.

MASON

They staple the bags shut for safety and I'm not allowed to open them.

The large man rolls his eyes.

LARGE MAN

Great. It better be here.

He slams the door shut. Mason flicks off the door. While walking back to the car, he marks the order as completed.

The interface shows his pay: \$5.45 + \$0.55 TIP.

MASON

How generous.

Mason steps into his car, closes the door, and puts both his hands on the wheel. He SHOUTS to relieve his frustration. After a second, he puts his car into forward and drives off.

INT. MASON'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

Mason unlocks the door to his apartment. On the inside is a modest one bedroom apartment.

Mason sets his keys down on the counter of a small kitchen and sits down on a couch in his small living room. Leaning forward on the couch and playing *Fortnite* is NOAH QUINN.

Noah, Mason's roommate and long-term best friend is a bit goofy and can be intense, but only for his platonic love for Mason.

NOAH

(on headset)

He's one! I got the guy on the right, can you finish him off?

Mason chuckles.

MASON

Finish him off? Hopefully you took him on a date first, right?

Mason nudges his elbow into Noah. Noah removes his headset from his left ear.

NOAH

(to friend on headset)

One sec.

(MORE)

NOAH (CONT'D)
(to Mason)
What's up?

MASON
Nothing.

Mason goes on his phone and starts scrolling through social media. Noah loudly continues playing *Fortnite*.

NOAH
(on headset)
He's one! He's one! He's on your
left, I'm going in!

Noah gets the final kill on an enemy. VICTORY ROYALE!

NOAH (CONT'D)
Great work! Alright, Mason got
home, I'm gonna get off. Talk to
you later? Alright. Yep. See ya.

Noah turns off his Xbox and sets his headset down.

MASON
Congrats.

NOAH
On what?

Mason points at the TV.

MASON
Your win.

NOAH
(laughs)
Oh, thanks.

Noah gets up and walks to the kitchen.

NOAH
What have you been up to?

MASON
(lying)
Dude, you wouldn't believe it! I
actually booked an acting gig!

NOAH
Holy shit! Really? Let's celebrate!

Noah reaches into a cabinet above the fridge and pulls out some booze. Mason is surprised that Noah bought his lie so easily.

MASON

What? No, dude, I was joking.

Noah grabs a bottle of vodka and closes the pantry door.

NOAH

Why would you joke about that? Is it fun for you to lie and make me think that my best friend achieved his dream? It's not funny.

Mason is uncomfortable by how convictive Noah is. Noah walks over to him.

NOAH

Gotcha! You should've seemed how uncomfortable you looked.

Mason and Noah laugh.

NOAH

What actually happened?

MASON

I did Doordash deliveries for like 8 hours and made 90 bucks.

NOAH

That's not bad!

MASON

Oh, God, it's so bad. Imagine driving in bumper-to-bumper traffic and getting yelled by angry men all day for minimum wage.
(sarcastically)
I love it!

Noah holds up the bottle of vodka he grabbed earlier.

NOAH

I've been waiting

Mason loves this idea.

MASON

Yes!

A few quick cuts of Noah and Mason taking shots. Music blares as they excitedly shout while downing alcohol.

SMASH CUT TO:

A little while later, Mason lies quietly on the floor while Noah dances to himself.

The music plays quietly as Mason stares at a SECURITY CAMERA in the corner. The two drunkenly ramble to each other.

MASON

Do you ever worry that you're going to die and ultimately be completely insignificant?

NOAH

Why do you ask?

MASON

I dunno. I just feel like I'm a waste right now. I want to be famous.

NOAH

You do NOT want to be famous. Remember what happened to Britney Spears? Fame changes people. We're real. You. Me? We're real as shit. Celebrities aren't real. They're fake.

MASON

I guess.

Mason continues staring into the distance.

MASON

But... I at least can't stand being this NOT famous. Like, it's so stereotypical for an acting major to be a complete failure but how have I gone this long without getting a role?

NOAH

Hey, am I not enough for you?

MASON

Shut up. You're ridiculous.

NOAH

Don't worry dude, you'll get a role soon. I can sense it.

A beat.

NOAH (CONT'D)
Alright, it's bed time for me. I
call the bed tonight!

MASON
Remind me why we decided to get a
one bedroom apartment?

NOAH
Because you're a poor, failed,
loser actor and I enjoy your
company so much!

MASON
Right, but you can afford to get a
better apartment, why don't we just
get a two bedroom?

NOAH
Once you get your big gig, we can
move up.

Noah walks to the bedroom and closes the door. Mason walks to the bathroom and pees while brushing his teeth. He walks to the couch and reaches underneath for a box with a blanket and a pillow. He goes to sleep.

INT. MASON'S APARTMENT - MORNING

Mason wakes up to the sound of popcorn being microwaved by Noah. He checks his phone: 12:04 PM. He reaches for a water bottle and takes a big swig before getting up.

NOAH
Rise and shine, sleepy head! I've
made you breakfast!

Mason looks around for said breakfast.

MASON
Where?

Noah turns to the microwave and pulls out the bag of popped popcorn.

NOAH
Here you go!

MASON
Mmm. Popcorn! You're such a great
cook.

Noah takes a bow. Mason dumps the popcorn into a bowl and starts eating it. He scrolls through his phone.

MASON

Oh, shit!

NOAH

What?

MASON

It looks like I have a job offer!

NOAH

(not buying it)

Suuuure. Is it even bigger than the one you got yesterday?

MASON

Dude, I'm serious his time.

NOAH

Wait, really?

Mason shows him his phone. An email from his acting agent reads: "Great news! An acting gig has opened up (finally)!"

NOAH

Holy shit!

MASON

Right?!

Noah hugs Mason.

NOAH

Great work!

MASON

Only thing is... I don't know what it is.

NOAH

Oh no. Is it a scam again? Remember what happened when you put a thousand bucks into that cryptocurrency? Don't give them any money!

MASON

It's not a scam, this is an official thing from my agent.

NOAH

Agent? They aren't doing a very good job at representing you.

MASON

Yeah. A job is a job, though!

NOAH

You're right!

(looking at his phone)

What does it pay?

Mason scrolls through his phone. A promised "BIG PAYOUT" is mentioned, but no specifics.

MASON

Don't know that either.

Noah rolls his eyes.

NOAH

(frustrated)

Dude! This is such a scam.

Mason brushes off Noah's frustration.

MASON

It says to show up tonight at some event. Apparently the pay is pretty good.

Noah crosses his fingers.

NOAH

Let's hope it's not a scam!

MASON

It's not a scam! Mason Grant has just gotten his big break!

Mason throws up his arms in celebration.

MATCH CUT TO:

INT. MANSION - DAY

Inside a LARGE MANSION is a loud bunch of kids celebrating somebody's birthday. People are screaming, music for little kids is blaring, and the house is noisily decorated with bright colors, confetti, and glitter.

In a CLOWN COSTUME is Mason, slumped forward. Mason's costume has frosting from a cake smeared on it. He looks tired as hell.

Mason scrolls through his phone and calls Noah. After a few rings, he picks up.

NOAH (O.S.)
Yo! How's the gig going?

MASON
It's a fucking birthday party. I'm
in a goddamned clown costume.

Noah laughs loudly and obnoxiously over the phone. Mason doesn't appreciate this. After catching his breath:

NOAH
A birthday party?! No fucking way!
How did you get hired for that?

MASON
I don't know. I have no clue who
even hired me, but I'm assuming
he's a rich idiot.

NOAH
Hey, money is money!

MASON
It's embarrassing. These kids are
so fucking annoy-

Mason trails off as a LITTLE BOY walks over. Mason puts his phone down.

LITTLE BOY
You aren't supposed to be using bad
language.

Mason stands up and starts acting like a clown again.

MASON
(in clown voice)
Little boys shouldn't be listening
to other people's conversations! I
was talking to the circus about our
next big act. Do you want to join
the circus?

LITTLE BOY
No. I'm an actor. My mom says that
I'm going to be very famous one
day.

Mason stares at the little kid. His blank expression makes the kid walk away.

MASON

Fuck this.

Mason steps out of the house.

INT. MASON'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

Mason walks into the apartment dressed in his clown costume. The makeup has started to wash off. He looks gross. Noah's playing *Fortnite* again. He looks up from his game.

NOAH

(to headset, laughing)

Guys? I have to go. Something just came up.

Mason walks over and puts his hand up.

MASON

I don't want to hear it.

Noah looks at him and tries to hold in a laugh. He fails. His loud cackling gets on Mason's nerves, but Mason also sports a slight smile seeing how happy Noah is.

MASON

(playfully)

Stop it! You're such an asshole.

NOAH

We have some alcohol from earlier this week, you look like you could use some.

MASON

Fuck it, my day couldn't get any worse.

CUT TO:

Later, Mason sits on the floor of his kitchen, talking to somebody on the phone.

GIRL OVER PHONE (O.S.)

It's not you, it's me. I just can't sit here while you chase success that isn't coming.

MASON

Babe, please. Don't do this. I need you right now.

GIRL OVER PHONE (O.S.)

I'm sorry. Bye, Mason.

She hands up. Mason sits there for a little while, looking off.

NOAH

(yelling)

Get over here, dude! Dance with me!

Mason takes a deep sigh before getting up. He walks to the living room, where Noah is dancing to a loud song.

NOAH

What was that all about?

MASON

Nothing. I'm single now.

Noah is taken aback. He turns the music down.

NOAH

Oh. I'm sorry to hear that. But, between you and me, I always hated Sarah.

Mason nods his head.

MASON

What was that song you wanted to show me?

NOAH

Are you sure you don't wanna talk about it?

Mason nods again. Noah turns off the music. His dancing makes Mason happy enough to start dancing himself.

The music is slowly faded out while Mason continues to dance, until:

CUT TO:

The next morning, Mason lies on the couch, snoring. A POUNDING on the door is heard. Mason jolts awake.

Another POUNDING.

MASON

Who the hell is there?

No response. Mason struggles to get out of his couch. He puts on slides and walks to the door.

There's nobody behind the door. Mason looks up and down the hallway. A shadowed figure turns the corner.

MASON

Hello?

Mason starts to slowly close the door. He notices a letter on the floor.

Picking it up, Mason walks back to the apartment. Noah walks out of his room, looking groggy.

NOAH

What was that?

MASON

I'm not sure. Somebody dropped off a letter.

NOAH

Another clown gig? Looks like you could make a business out of this.

MASON

Shut up.

Mason tears open the letter. He briefly scans it before tossing it to the side.

MASON

It's another unspecified acting request. Screw that.

NOAH

(teasing)

You sure you don't wanna take it?
This might be your big break.

Mason laughs.

MASON

Yeah, totally. Whatever, I'm going to do some deliveries. Gotta make that money somehow.

Noah nods. Mason grabs his keys and walks out his door.

MONTAGE - DRIVING

Mason drives around the city with the life drained out of his eyes. He picks up orders from various restaurants and drives to customers.

Stuck in more traffic, Mason looks into the distance, switching between checking his phone and moving a few feet forward.

Mason KNOCKS on the door of various houses. People grab their orders from him.

A CHA-CHING is heard every time a customer picks up the order.

The light drains from the sky as Mason continues his very long shift.

Mason fills his car up with gas and anxiously watches as the price rises.

At night, Mason drops off one more order and looks into the living room of a house.

A movie is playing - *The Truman Show* - one of Mason's favorites. He longingly looks before the door opens up.

MASON

Here ya go!

The large man from earlier opens the door. He looks angry.

LARGE MAN

It's you again. You're fifteen minutes late.

MASON

Traffic. Maybe if you gave me a tip I would've gotten here faster.

LARGE MAN

What the hell did you say to me?

Mason gives a hard stare to the man. He's fed up with his shit. He takes the bag of food and SLAMS it on the ground. He stomps on it to make sure it's ruined.

LARGE MAN

What the FUCK did you just do?
You're so fucked, kid.

MASON

Call Doordash support, asshole.
They'll give you a refund.

Mason flicks the man off as he walks away. The man looks incredibly angry and gets onto his phone.

Mason drives home, and gets a DING from his Doordash app.

He looks at the app to see a large RED banner. DEACTIVATED.
Mason tosses his phone to the side.

END MONTAGE

INT. MASON'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

Mason walks in again, looking more sluggish than ever. Noah plays *Fortnite*.

NOAH

(to headset)

I cracked him! I'm medding up, give
me a second before we fight.

Mason walks to the couch and scrolls through his phone. None of his apps are interesting anymore.

He looks to the letter he opened up earlier. Back to his phone.

After a beat, he gets up and walks to the letter, scanning through it again.

The letter reads: "CONGRATULATIONS, you have been selected for the acting opportunity of a lifetime. We cannot reveal the details here, but we encourage you to visit our office at 1400 Orange Parkway to receive details. This is an exclusive opportunity that will reward you handsomely. We are open 24 hours a day."

Mason looks intrigued by this. He looks at Noah, who's still playing his game, before getting up.

EXT. STREET - NIGHT

Mason slowly drives down a road marked Orange Parkway. He looks down the street -- 1600... 1580... 1560... -- he gets the pattern.

Mason speeds a bit before looking back -- 1440... 1420... 1380... -- Mason SLAMS on the brakes. He looks confused.

Putting the car into reverse, Mason looks back at 1420 Orange Parkway. There's a small gate in between 1420 and 1380.

Past the gate is a dimly lit alleyway that looks straight out of a horror movie.

MASON

(to self)

Oh, god. Why am I doing this to myself?

Mason's phone DINGS. It's the CHA-CHING from his Doordash app. He checks the notification: "Account permanently deactivated. Sorry to see you go!"

That's the sign. Mason sighs, puts his car into park, and gets out.

Mason opens the CREAKY gate meanders down the alleyway with caution.

After walking for a little while, he sees BLACK BUILDING with no markings.

Mason pulls up his phone and texts Noah: "abt to enter weird building. if i die pls tell my family i died bravely or smthn"

Turning off his phone, Mason steps inside.

INT. MYSTERIOUS BUILDING / OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

The building is sleek and fancy on the inside. Marble floors, large pillars, etc. A RECEPTIONIST sits at a large desk.

RECEPTIONIST

Mr. Grant? We've been expecting you.

Mason nods his head cautiously.

MASON

Oh? Okay.

RECEPTIONIST

Follow me.

The receptionist leads Mason down a lengthy hallway. Movie posters line the walls, but none of them are recognizable.

MASON

What's the deal with these posters?

RECEPTIONIST
Previous projects.

MASON
I don't recognize any of them.

RECEPTIONIST
That's alright.

Mason squints his eyes in confusion. He continues walking. At the end of the hallway, a BEAUTIFUL, ADORNED DOOR.

The receptionist knocks TWICE. After a beat, she knocks THREE TIMES, quicker than before. She quickly opens the door.

The receptionist doesn't enter, and signals for Mason to enter.

MASON
Just me?

The receptionist nods.

MASON
(uneasy)
Uh, alright.

Mason steps into a large office. A NICELY DRESSED MAN pours himself a drink on a little bar in the back. Mason puts his hands in his pockets.

MYSTERIOUS MAN
Hello, Mason Grant.

MASON
You can just call me Mason.

The man brings two drinks to the desk and sits down. He offers a glass to Mason, who declines.

MYSTERIOUS MAN
I insist.

MASON
(after a pause, slowly)
Okay.

Mason slowly drinks his glass of a dark-colored alcohol.

MYSTERIOUS MAN
Do you know why I brought you here today, Mason Grant?

MASON
Mason. And no.

MYSTERIOUS MAN
We were impressed with your
portfolio and believe that you are
well-suited for this position.

Mason looks confused.

MASON
Portfolio?

MYSTERIOUS MAN
The one on your YouTube channel.

Mason thinks hard about this.

INT. HOUSE - DAY - FLASHBACK

A YOUNG MASON (~16) acts in a short film. He's fake making-
out with a GIRL. A YOUNG NOAH storms into the room. They suck
at acting. Melodramatic music plays in the background.

TEENAGE MASON
Charles! I didn't think you would
come in!

TEENAGE NOAH
Richard, you bastard! I'm going to
kill you for this.

A closeup on Mason, who DESPERATELY tries to form a tear. A
jarring cut to water on his face.

TEENAGE MASON
I'm so sorry... how can you ever
forgive me?

End flashback.

INT. OFFICE - NIGHT

Back to the office.

MASON
Oh... that one? Yeah, that was some
of my best work.

MYSTERIOUS MAN
We're here today to offer you an
acting residency.

MASON
Residency?

The man reaches into his suit pocket and pulls out an envelope. Mason takes a slow sip of his drink.

MYSTERIOUS MAN
Inside that envelope is a check for
\$5 million.

Mason does a spit-take.

MASON
\$5 million?!

MYSTERIOUS MAN
Yes. You'll be a key part in a live-
entertainment experience. It's a
three-year commitment.

MASON
'Live-entertainment experience'?
What's that? Three years?

The man ignores the question.

MYSTERIOUS MAN
You'll be provided with housing,
food, and job security. It's
everything you've ever wanted.

Mason takes a deep breath. He's conflicted.

MASON
I don't know...

MYSTERIOUS MAN
You'll be a real actor with an
established presence on the screen.
No more clown work; you'll be known
all over.

MASON
How'd you know about the cl-

MYSTERIOUS MAN
Here's the thing: I need you to
sign now.

The man pushes a tall stack of papers forward. Mason looks at the stack and riffles through. The man pulls a pen out of his pocket and offers it to Mason.

MASON
(reassuring himself)
\$5 million, huh?

The man nods. Mason takes another deep breath. He picks up the pen and SIGNS the contract.

MYSTERIOUS MAN
Congratulations, Mason. You'll be a star. You leave tomorrow.

MASON
Tomorrow?

MYSTERIOUS MAN
Yes. Production begins on Wednesday.

The man stands up and offers Mason a handshake. Mason returns it. The man hands the envelope to Mason.

MASON
(proud)
\$5 million! Shit.

The man smiles. Mason walks out of the room. After leaving, the man's cellphone rings.

MYSTERIOUS MAN
It's done. Send in Victoria.

EXT. STREET - CONTINUOUS

Mason walks out of the building and back down the alley. He's got a pep in his step that he didn't have before.

Pulling out his phone, Mason calls Noah.

MASON
Hey Noah? We're partying tonight.
Invite all of our friends over.

Mason confidently walks to his car.

INT. MASON'S APARTMENT - NIGHT / MORNING

Mason walks down the apartment hallway and hears loud music thumping from his apartment as he approaches.

After opening the door:

NOAH
(shouting)
Congratulations!!

Noah throws around some confetti. Mason looks in. There's only one other person here, GREG (nerdy), who Mason doesn't know.

MASON
Where is everybody? I told you to
invite all of our friends!

NOAH
Mason, we don't have any friends.
Jordy was going to come, but he
canceled.

Mason points to Greg.

MASON
Who's this chud?

NOAH
This 'chud' is Greg. He's our
neighbor.

GREG
Hi.

MASON
Hi, Greg. I'm Mason.

GREG
I've heard! You're a famous actor,
right? What would I recognize you
from.

Mason chuckles.

MASON
I'm not famous yet. My first gig
starts soon.

GREG
Oh! Congrats.

Mason looks around the apartment. It's messily decorated with CONFETTI, streamers, and balloons. While not stylish, Mason loves it.

MASON
Thanks for decorating, Noah.

NOAH
Of course! I knew this day would
come, I had this all packed away.

Mason looks at the bar. Bottles of alcohol are lined up.

MASON
Wanna start drinking?

GREG
Hell yes!

A short montage shows Mason, Noah, and Greg getting wildly
drunk. Party animals!

Later, Greg sits on the couch. Noah is standing in another
room, dancing to himself. Mason walks over. Noah continues
dancing.

MASON
Hey, Noah?

NOAH
What's up?

MASON
Okay, I haven't told you the job
details yet. It's a lot.

NOAH
Hit me.

MASON
I'm getting five million.

Noah stops ABRUPTLY.

NOAH
Five million... dollars?

Mason nods.

NOAH
No way. No fucking way.

MASON
Yeah.

Noah SCREAMS in joy.

NOAH
(excitedly)
You're a movie star! What's the
project, anyway?

MASON
I don't know the specifics of it...
but I'll be gone for three years.

Noah doesn't like this news.

NOAH
What? How on Earth - three years?

Mason shrugs.

MASON
I'm getting flown out for filming
tomorrow.

Noah scrunches his eyebrows.

NOAH
Oh.

MASON
Yeah.

Noah slides against the wall. Mason sits next to him. A beat.

NOAH
Three years... wow.

The two sit there while the music continues to play. Greg
walks into the room.

GREG
What's up, guys?

MASON
(quickly)
Now now, Greg!

Greg quickly walks back to the other room. Noah chuckles.

NOAH
You're getting a lot of money.

MASON
I know. You have to understand that
I MUST do this.

NOAH
If you didn't you'd be an idiot.
Trust me, I understand.

Noah eyes tear up. Mason gives him a hug.

MASON
I love you, man.

NOAH
I love you, too.

After a beat:

NOAH
You can take the bed tonight. It
being your last night and all.

MASON
You've been hogging it for the past
week so, yeah, I'd be a bit peeved
if you didn't give it to me.

Mason chuckles. He gets up, and pulls Noah up with him. They
walk into the living room.

MASON
Greg! Get over here! Let's play
drunk Monopoly!

Mason busts out a board of Monopoly. We see the players make
a few moves around the board. Noah gets a monopoly. Greg has
to make a big payout to Noah. Mason goes to jail. As they
play, we slowly see the rest of the living room.

The next morning, Mason has one suitcase and a backpack. The
game of Monopoly is on the floor, unfinished. Greg is gone.
Noah stands in the kitchen.

NOAH
Is that everything?

MASON
I'm not sure. They didn't tell me
what I'd need to pack for three
years. I was told everything was
covered, so I might not even need
clothes.

NOAH
Fuck, man!

MASON
What?

Noah shakes his head.

NOAH
What the hell am I going to do
without you?

MASON

I dunno.

(beat)

If you are staying in this
godforsaken apartment, don't you
DARE get a new roommate.

NOAH

(laughs)

I won't. Who'd want to live with
me, anyways?

MASON

Good point. I can guarantee nobody
else wants to deal with your
Fortnite screeching each night.

Noah smiles.

MASON (CONT'D)

Alright. I gotta get going.

NOAH

(groans)

Don't leave me, dude! What am I
saying? Get the hell out of here.
Make that bank.

Noah walks over to Mason and gives him a hug. After a beat:

MASON

See ya.

NOAH

Show those Hollywood assholes who's
the next big thing!

Mason takes a deep breath, then nods before exiting.

INT. UBER - LATER

Mason sits quietly in an Uber with his stuff. He's not on his
phone, instead sporting a smile as he looks out the window.

The UBER DRIVER (60s, gruff) looks in his rearview mirror.

UBER DRIVER

First time in Atlanta?

MASON

(happily)

Nope. I'm leaving for the first
time in years.

UBER DRIVER
Why are ya leaving?

MASON
I got my big break!

UBER DRIVER
Acting?

Mason nods.

UBER DRIVER
I've driven plenty of young actors
in my time. Want my advice?

MASON
Sure?

UBER DRIVER
Watch your back.

Taken aback by this comment, Mason looks uneasy. He looks into the corner of the car and sees a small camera.

MASON
I'm sorry?

UBER DRIVER
You will be lied to. People without
a spine will crumble under the
pressure. This business will chew
you up and spit you out.

MASON
How do you know so much?

The driver gives a menacing stare through the mirror. Mason awkwardly adjusts himself. After a moment.

UBER DRIVER
I'm an actor, too.

MASON
Oh? Anything I'd know you from?

UBER DRIVER
Not yet.

Mason awkwardly laughs. He turns his phone on and starts scrolling through social media.

Later, the car comes to a stop. Mason looks up from his phone.

UBER DRIVER

We're here.

MASON

Already? That was quick.

UBER DRIVER

Yup.

Mason packs up his things and steps out of the car. The driver rolls down his window. He stares at Mason, looking like he's about to say something.

Mason looks back, but after realizing he has nothing to say, he turns around. What a weirdo.

In front of Mason stands a SMALL BUILDING located on a large runway. He checks his phone. It's the right place.

I/E. RUNWAY BUILDING / RUNWAY - DAY

Mason steps into a small office. A RECEPTIONIST sits at a desk. She looks up.

RECEPTIONIST

Mr. Grant?

MASON

That's me!

RECEPTIONIST

Your transportation is waiting for you on the runway.

Mason looks beyond a large window at the runway.

MASON

(pointing)

That runway?

RECEPTIONIST

You see another one?

MASON

Good point.

Mason exits the building.

Walking down the runway, Mason sees a LUXURY private jet. There aren't any other on the strip. He looks around - is this right? - and walks to it.

As he gets closer, he sees an FLIGHT ATTENDANT waiting outside.

FLIGHT ATTENDANT
Mr. Grant?

MASON
Uh, yeah.

FLIGHT ATTENDANT
Welcome aboard.

Mason climbs into the jet.

INT. PRIVATE JET - DAY

Inside, the plane is STUNNING. It's the kind of luxury that would be imagined to be used by the .1%. Mason's jaw drops as he looks around.

MASON
Wow.

Mason sees a spread of meat, cheese, and caviar. He sees a small plate and loads it up, eating some as he does so.

MASON
(chewing)
This is included, yes?

The flight attendant nods.

FLIGHT ATTENDANT
We'll be leaving soon, Mr. Grant.
Please take a seat.

MASON
Don't mind if I do.

Mason plops himself down in a LUXURY seat. A video on a monitor in front of him starts playing.

Over a sweeping view of a small town, we hear a NARRATOR.
NOTE: This town and the actors included in the video will be seen later on WARREN ISLAND, where the experiment takes place.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
You are about to embark on the
adventure of a lifetime, Mason
Grant.

Mason wasn't listening to the video until he heard his name. This piques his attention.

Stock-footage-looking shots show different actors interacting, laughing, and having a good time.

NARRATOR (V.O.)

Over the next three years, you will be an integral part in the next level of live entertainment media. You have been carefully selected for your skills, personal experiences, and unique point of view.

Mason rolls his eyes.

MASON

(under breath)

Did an AI write this?

FLIGHT ATTENDANT

(from back)

Please pay attention, Mr. Grant.

Mason turns around, shocked that the flight attendant was listening. He looks at the video cautiously.

In the video, more sweeping shots of the town as well as some of the inhabitants.

NARRATOR (V.O.)

Your participation in this experience will challenge you, but you will be handsomely rewarded. On Warren Island, you will find a home, a new community, and solace. Thank you, and good luck.

Mason looks confused as all hell.

MASON

(to flight attendant)

What was that video all about?

FLIGHT ATTENDANT

The plane has landed, Mr. Grant. Feel free to leave.

MASON

It - what?

Mason looks at the window. The plane landed. He shakes his head.

MASON

Uh, alright. Thank you.

FLIGHT ATTENDANT

Good luck out there.

Mason steps off of the plane. A large tunnel connects the exit to the next location. Mason walks down the tunnel. It's dark.

Eventually, he arrives at a large door.

INT. WAREHOUSE / MAXINE'S OFFICE / WAREHOUSE - DAY

On the inside of the door is an ENORMOUS WAREHOUSE. A large number of cubicles with tall walls fill up the building, but in the center lies a path to an office on the other side.

Mason walks down the pathway and looks at the cubicles. In each one is a writer, furiously writing out a script on a typewriter.

Each cubicle has the name of an actor along with their headshot and character name in quotations.

Mason gets to the end of the hallway and knocks on a large door.

OLDER WOMAN

(from inside)

Come in!

Mason approaches a LARGE DESK. An OLDER, SHREWD-LOOKING WOMAN sits atop the desk, looking down on Mason.

This woman is MAXINE BLACKWOOD. Hardened by her years as a Hollywood executive, Maxine doesn't take shit from anybody. She's no fun, that's for sure.

MAXINE

Hello, Mason Grant.

MASON

Mason.

MAXINE

What's that?

MASON

Oh, you can just call me Mason.

MAXINE

Attitude already? Hm.

Mason looks uncomfortable at Maxine's aggression to him.

MASON
(appeasing)
Don't worry, you can call me
whatever you want!

MAXINE
Do you not trust my judgement, Mr.
Grant?

MASON
(embarrassed)
Of course not! Sorry.

MAXINE
Hmph.
(beat)
Take a seat.

Mason takes a seat and awkwardly fidgets.

MAXINE
Welcome to Warren Island. I assume
you have a few questions about your
job?

MASON
I do! I'm not sure about...
anything that's going on.

MAXINE
You'll figure out more of the
details as you go along, but here's
your assignment for now.

Maxine pushes a tall script of papers in front of Mason.

On the front is a page simply marked with a week: 1.14.24 -
1.20.24, and "THORIN HORNSBY".

MASON
Thorin Hornsby? What is this?

MAXINE
That's you!

MASON
Odd name.

MAXINE
Edward is a fan of *The Hobbit*,
Thorin is the king of the dwarves.

MASON
Oh? That's interesting.

MAXINE
This is your script assignment. I expect you to memorize this by the end of the week and be able to perform it.

MASON
Perform it where?

MAXINE
Everywhere.

MASON
I don't understand.

MAXINE
Did you not read the contract?

Mason rubs his neck.

MASON
(embarrassed)
Uh... no.

MAXINE
Warren Island is a 24/7 entertainment experience. Every hour of the day, bar those where you are sleeping, you will be expected to perform this script. You will play the man named on your script.

MASON
I - how am I supposed to memorize it all?

MAXINE
Mason, you signed off on a script. That's your job to figure it out.

MASON
What am I performing?

Maxine slides over a photo of a rich-looking MAN CHILD.

MAXINE
This is Edward Warren. Edward is the founder of this experiment. You will be putting on a show for him.

MASON

Didn't they already make this a movie?

MAXINE

Edward is aware of the actors involved in this. He simply tells us his requests for the week, and every actor is given their script of what to follow.

Mason flips through the script.

MAXINE (CONT'D)

It looks a lot like one of those choose-your-own-adventure books. If Edward does something, you have to make sure that you perform your action accordingly. Every possible decision that Edward is planning on making will be accounted for.

Mason looks overwhelmed.

MASON

Wow. This is... a lot. So, if I'm not interacting with Mason, can I do what I want?

MAXINE

That depends. If you're doing your job and have your lines memorized, then yes. There are cameras recording at all times to ensure that you aren't slacking off when you should be focusing.

MASON

So, I memorize my lines for my interactions with this Edward guy, and when he's doing other things I can work on my own stuff?

MAXINE

Yes. Keep in mind that you have no access to technology, as per Edward's request. If a script calls for a computer you will be given limited access and a password to use for your role only. For now, I need to collect all of your devices.

MASON

Wait, I can't use my phone?

MAXINE

I'm afraid not. It was in the contract.

Frustrated by this information, Mason reluctantly reaches into his pocket and turns his phone in.

MASON

Who will I contact in case of an emergency?

MAXINE

(scoffs)

Oh, there won't be any emergencies. We've designed this to be as safe as possible for all participants.

MASON

Yeah, but *what if* something happens?

Maxine looks frustrated by his line of questioning. She glances at a paper to her side.

MAXINE

I have a Mr. Noah Quinn on file in case of emergency. Does that answer your question?

Mason gives a confirmatory thumbs up.

MAXINE

Great. Let's move on. Follow me.

Maxine gets up and walks out of her office. Mason glances around the room again before exiting.

As Maxine struts down the warehouse, Mason looks at the cubicles.

MASON

What's up with these cubicles?

MAXINE

Each of our talented writers is currently writing the scripts for next week.

MASON

I assume that the images on the outside are of other actors? How many are there?

MAXINE

Your assumption would be correct, and I would estimate we have a few dozen actors currently employed.

Mason tries to find a cubicle with his name on it, but doesn't see any in the sea of other cubicles.

The two step out a side door.

EXT. WARREN ISLAND - CONTINUOUS

Outside, Maxine gets into a golf cart. Mason takes a seat, and a DRIVER takes them on a tour of the island.

We see the great expanse of WARREN ISLAND as Mason sees it for the first time. It's a meticulously planned city, much like one in North Korea or in a movie like *The Truman Show* or *Vivarium*.

In a grocery store, actors move through the store, somewhat robotically.

MASON

Am I able to use that grocery store?

Maxine turns to look at it.

MAXINE

Actors are not permitted to use that grocery store. Your supplies will be delivered to your quarters each week.

As they drive, Mason notices a half-finished LARGE SCHOOL under construction.

MASON

What's up with the construction?

MAXINE

That's the University of Warren. Construction will finish by the beginning of next week.

MASON

Really? That's so soon.

No response from Maxine. After a bit more driving, the golf cart stops. Mason looks at a row of houses, each identical to its neighbor.

MAXINE

This is where you'll live.

MASON

This one?

Mason points to the house right in front of him. Maxine scoffs.

MAXINE

No. This one.

Maxine points to the house directly on the left. Mason chuckles.

MAXINE

Is there are problem?

MASON

It's just... they all look the same.

MAXINE

Each house is perfectly designed in Edward's vision. I would caution you against your hubris going forward.

Mason is taken aback by her comment.

MASON

Sorry. It won't happen again.

Maxine gives a stern nod. She walks up to the house and unlocks it with her key. She doesn't enter.

MAXINE

Your stuff is inside. Make sure everything is memorized by Friday.

Maxine gets back in the golf car and drives off. Mason steps in the home.

INT. MASON'S HOME - CONTINUOUS

Mason takes in his surroundings. He sets the script on the kitchen counter.

Inside, the house is smaller than it looks from the outside. The layout is identical to his apartment, although it's significantly cleaner and has different material.

The carpeted floor is a change of pace for Mason, who reaches down and feels it. He looks to the bedroom.

MASON

A bed for myself? Finally.

On cue: **a doorbell rings.**

Mason stops searching his house and opens the door.

Standing in the doorway is VICTORIA CHEN (20s, nerdy, wide-eyed). She holds onto her large script in one arm, and gives a cute wave to Mason in the other.

VICTORIA

Hi! I'm Victoria. Victoria Chen.

Victoria extends her hand for a handshake. Mason accepts, but is a bit confused.

MASON

Hi... I'm Mason. Mason Grant.

VICTORIA

Can I come in?

MASON

Uh, I guess.

Victoria enters. Mason stands around awkwardly.

MASON

So, are you my neighbor or something?

Victoria turns to Mason with a look of concern.

VICTORIA

What? No. I'm your wife.

Mason lets out a confused chuckle.

MASON

What?

VICTORIA

I play Ryan, your wife. We live together.

MASON

My wife? What are you talking about?

VICTORIA

Have you not read your script?

Victoria points to Mason's script, sitting on the counter. Now he realized what's happening.

MASON

Oh! You play my wife in the show. I wasn't expecting to have a wife, or that I'd have to live with someone else.

VICTORIA

Well... I'm here!

The two stand awkwardly together. After a second:

VICTORIA

I'm sorry, can we hug? I feel like I need to take the tension down.

Mason pauses to think.

MASON

Sure.

The two go in for a hug. Victoria is energetic, and Mason is uncomfortable at first. He smiles after a second. They break apart.

VICTORIA

Thanks. That helped.

MASON

Of course.

Another awkward beat. Victoria yawns.

VICTORIA

It's about time for bed, don't you think?

Mason looks at the clock on the microwave. **2:04 A.M.**

MASON

That can't be right.

VICTORIA

What's that?

MASON

It says it's in the morning, but it was pretty bright outside a few minutes ago.

VICTORIA

Are you sure? It was pretty dark when I arrived.

Mason thinks about it. *Was it dark?* He shrugs it off.

MASON

I'm not sure. I am tired, though.

VICTORIA

I can take the couch for tonight! I'm sure you wanted that bed and I know you didn't expect anybody else would be sleeping here.

Mason did want the bed, but he wasn't raised that way.

MASON

Oh God, no! You should definitely take it!

VICTORIA

I couldn't do that. Just take it!

MASON

Seriously. I insist.

Victoria relents.

VICTORIA

Alright! Remember though, I offered it!

Mason smiles.

MASON

Yeah, don't worry about it.

He stands in the bedroom for a moment. She looks around, waiting for him to leave.

MASON

Sorry! I'll leave now.

Mason steps out of the room and into the living room.

Getting ready for bed, Mason lays on the couch awkwardly. He turns to look under the bed for the box of blankets, but decides against it.

He continues laying there for another second. *Why not check it?* He gets up and looks under the couch. He sees a box underneath it.

Sliding the box out, he sees just what he was looking for. A blanket and a pillow.

MASON
(to self)
What are the odds?

Mason suspiciously looks around the room. He decides that it was just a coincidence, then covers himself with the blanket and goes to bed.

INT. MASON'S HOME - MORNING

The sound of eggs cracking into a pan -- bacon sizzling.

Mason is jolted awake. He rubs his eyes and sees Victoria cooking breakfast. He looks at the clock: **7:13 AM.**

MASON
It's pretty early for breakfast,
isn't it?

Victoria looks at the clock on the microwave.

VICTORIA
It's a quarter past seven, don't
most people eat by now?

Mason chuckles.

MASON
I get up by 10:00 at the earliest
back at home. This is certainly an
adjustment.

Victoria looks to her script, seemingly memorizing her lines before plating up fried eggs and bacon onto two plates, placing them on the counter.

VICTORIA
Breakfast is ready!

Mason looks up from the couch.

MASON
Wait, you made something for me?

VICTORIA
I'm your wife now, aren't I?
Figured I'd start acting like it.

Mason gets up and walks to the counter.

MASON
Uh... yeah. That *definitely* works
for me.

Mason digs in.

VICTORIA
Did you get a chance to work on
your script yet? You have a big
scene today.

Mason stops eating suddenly.

MASON
I do?

Victoria nods.

MASON
Shit. No. I've got to get on that.

Victoria slides the script to Mason, who opens it up.

The first page has a character description for Thorin
Hornsby. Mason reads out loud.

MASON
Thorin Hornsby, mid thirties -
wait, I'm not even close to my
thirties!

Victoria, reading from her script looks up.

VICTORIA
(sarcastically)
Really? I couldn't tell.

MASON
Seriously?

She gives a hard stare back.

MASON
Right. You're joking.

Victoria chuckles and continues reading.

MASON

Thorin is a teacher going through a crisis. Stuck teaching a film course at a small university, he puts aside his troubles to present as a happy teacher. His students adore him.

VICTORIA

You're so lucky! Your role has so much going on, mine is...

Victoria flips her script around to Mason. It reads "Ryan Hornsby, early 20s, is Thorin Hornsby's wife."

MASON

That's it?

(laughs, then realizes)

Early twenties? Why do you get to be in your twenties and I'm in my thirties?

VICTORIA

Why do you get to be 'adored by your students,' while my only character motivation is being married to you?

MASON

You're right, that's ridiculous. Oh, there's more to my character. Mind if I keep reading?

Victoria rolls her eyes.

VICTORIA

Nope, go ahead.

MASON

In his free time, Thorin enjoys spending time with Jacob Garnett, his closest friend, and Ryan Hornsby, his wife.

(looks up from script)

Do you have any idea who this Jacob guy is?

VICTORIA

Yeah. He's played by somebody named Rowan Thomas, who lives right next door to us.

MASON

How'd you figure that out?

Victoria reaches to the edge of the counter. She grabs a LARGE BINDER.

Inside the binder lies a series of laminated pages that include photos of actors involved and their character's names.

Mason starts flipping through the binder.

MASON

Woah... how many pages are in this?

While flipping through, he notices that each page has a few people with a red X over their image.

MASON

What's up with the red x's over these photos?

Mason shows the page to Victoria.

VICTORIA

I dunno.

Victoria looks closer at the image.

VICTORIA

It says "experiment terminated on February 13th"... no year, though.

Eventually, Mason flips to a page with a photo of a YOUNG, SMILING ACTOR. The photo identifies him as ROWAN THOMAS. Below him is a marking of his character name, "JACOB GARNETT."

MASON

Looks like a nice guy.

VICTORIA

Do you appear with him in a scene this week?

MASON

Again, haven't read my script yet. I need to get on that!

Mason sits back in a chair and reads through the first page of the script. After a beat, he realizes:

MASON

Oh shit! I'm supposed to be in class in--

Mason checks his watch. He groans.

MASON (CONT'D)
Fifteen minutes ago. Damn it.

Victoria reaches for a BACKPACK. She hands it to Mason.

VICTORIA
This should have everything you
need for the day! Get the hell out
of here!

MASON
Thanks, Vic.
(thinking)
Can I call you Vic?

Victoria nods. Mason awkwardly stands there for a second before waving and running out the house. Victoria cracks a smile.

INT. FILM CLASSROOM - AFTERNOON

Mason BURSTS through the door of a MEDIUM-SIZED LECTURE HALL. He hustles to the front, panting as he makes his way to a podium.

MASON
Sorry I'm late, students!

Mason surveys the class. Thirty or so students sit with blank computer screens in front of them, and hands crossed obediently.

Toward the back of the class is an OLDER STUDENT, about fifteen years his peers' senior. Unlike the other students, he lays back in his chair and sits on his phone with earbuds in.

Mason turns around and writes his name on his board. He writes "Ma," but quickly erases the a and turns it into an r. He finishes out "Mr. Hornsby."

MASON
My name is Thorin Hornsby, and I
will be your teacher this semester!

Mason places his script on the podium and flips to the first page.

MASON
(reading off script)
I'll call attendance first. Do we
have a Mark Anderson?

A MALE STUDENT raises his hand. Mason continues reading.

MASON (CONT'D)
Alright, how about a Michelle
Anderson?

A FEMALE STUDENT raises her hand. Mason points at the two.

MASON (CONT'D)
Siblings?

Both students freeze up and stare forward, not giving a
reaction.

MASON
Right...

Mason scans the classroom.

MASON
Most of these seats look full, so
I'll mark everybody off.

Mason checks off a list of generic sounding names -- like
Robert Smith, Ricardo Lopez, Mark Peters, etc. -- until he
gets to EDWARD WARREN's name. Mason looks interested.

MASON
(eagerly)
Before we continue, do we have an
Edward Warren here?

Mason looks around the classroom. Nobody responds.

MASON
No Edward?

The older student sitting in the back of the classroom
adjusts himself. Mason is confident that he's Edward.

MASON
(shouting)
Edward!

The older student removes an earbud.

OLDER STUDENT
What?

MASON
Are you Edward Warren?

OLDER STUDENT/EDWARD WARREN
I am. What does it matter?

Edward shoes Mason off.

EDWARD

Get back to teaching, or doing
whatever it is you were doing.

Mason slowly looks down at his paper and checks Edward's name off.

MASON

Great. It looks like everybody's
here! Today we'll be teaching.

Mason looks down at his script. It says **"Once Thorin takes attendance, he connects his laptop to an HDMI cable and plays the daily lecture."**

Mason reaches into his backpack and grabs his laptop. Once opening it up, he finds himself stuck at a password screen.

MASON

(quietly)

Password? What password?

Mason looks back at the script: **"Thorin briefly forgets his password, but after thinking about it he types in the code: 8492."**

Mason looks suspiciously at this note, and inputs the code into the computer. It opens up to a VIDEO.

Mason plugs the computer into an HDMI cable, which projects it onto a LARGE SCREEN behind him. Mason presses play.

On the video is an AI-ANIMATED MODEL of Mason. The model looks somewhat realistic but is deep into the uncanny valley. When he speaks, the voice sounds similar to Mason's, yet very different at the same time.

AI-GENERATED MASON

Hello, class. Today we will begin our first lecture. Directing. A film director is a person who controls a film's artistic and dramatic aspects and visualizes the screenplay (or script) while guiding the film crew and actors in the fulfillment of that vision. The director has a key role in choosing the cast members, production design and all the creative aspects of filmmaking.

As the voice drains on, Mason looks at the classroom. All of the students stare silently at the screen, except for Edward. Mason sits down and puts his head down.

RING!

The bell goes off, jolting Mason awake. He groggily pulls his head up and looks at the class. None of the students have gotten up yet.

MASON

Uh... you're free to go. Class dismissed!

Mason stands at the podium while waiting for students to leave. He looks at Edward, who quickly slips out of class.

INT. MASON'S HOME - NIGHT

Mason and Victoria eat spaghetti at the counter top in the kitchen.

MASON

(while eating)

It was so weird -- I thought this Edward dude was going to be interesting but he just sat on his phone.

VICTORIA

Really? That's odd. Maybe you'll have more to do later this week?

Mason pulls up his script and flips through it.

MASON

I checked through the rest of the script and... nothing. Every day consists of me playing some video in class and not interacting with him. Oh my god. You should've seen the video.

VICTORIA

What video?

MASON

They created this weird AI-generated version of me to teach the class. It's fucking weird.

Victoria laughs.

VICTORIA
Really? That's funny.

Mason thinks about it. It's not *that* funny. A KNOCK on the door. Mason looks to Victoria.

MASON
Who's that?

VICTORIA
I invited Rowan over for dinner!

MASON
Rowan, our neighbor?

VICTORIA
Yeah.

MASON
Uh, alright.

VICTORIA
What?

MASON
I just - never mind. I need to meet other people.

Mason walks to the door and opens it. ROWAN THOMAS (mid 20s, easy-going, funny) is standing at the door. He gives Mason a big HUG.

ROWAN
What's up, buddy?

Rowan releases the hug.

MASON
It's great to meet you, Rowan! I'm Mason.

Mason extends a handshake. Rowan accepts. He looks to Victoria, standing next to Mason.

ROWAN
Damn!

Rowan checks out Victoria.

MASON
Hey bro, watch out, that's my -

ROWAN

Wife? Yeah, I know. You're just lucky is all. You should see the bag of bones they put me with.

Mason and Victoria awkwardly laugh. A beat.

ROWAN

I'm joking! I'm alone.

The two let out a relieved laugh.

ROWAN

Yup...

Rowan stands around for a second.

VICTORIA

Oh! We're having dinner right now, would you like to join us?

ROWAN

(quickly)

Yes!

Victoria goes to the cabinet.

VICTORIA

We don't have any other plates. Mason, why don't you share with Rowan.

Mason shoots a glare at Victoria.

MASON

(slowly)

Of course -- sweetheart.

Mason and Rowan sit next to each other. Rowan leans over to eat Mason's food. Mason slides the plate to him.

MASON

I'm good. You can have it.

A beat.

MASON (CONT'D)

So -- what's your story, Rowan?

Rowan talks while eating.

ROWAN

I play this dude named Jacob who works at the grocery store.

Rowan digs into the corners of his brain to think of anything else. He gives up.

MASON

I meant, what's your *story*. Like, how did you get here? For example, I'm from Atlanta. I majored in acting at Emory University. Basic stuff like that.

ROWAN

Oh! I'm from Maitland, Florida, which is a small town near Orlando. I majored in finance at the University of Florida.

A beat.

VICTORIA

That's it?

Rowan nods.

VICTORIA

Alright. It's nice to meet you, Rowan. Well, I'm Victoria. I didn't go to college and live in Winter Park, Colorado.

ROWAN

Nice to meet you.

An awkward beat.

ROWAN

Well, I've got to get going.

MASON

Already? You just got here.

ROWAN

Gotta study for tomorrow's stuff! I have a big scene involving a spill in aisle nine!

Rowan gets up. Victoria and Mason exchange slightly confused looks to each other, but get up and walk him out.

MASON

Have a good night!

Mason closes the door.

MASON
What a weirdo.

VICTORIA
He seemed nice, I guess.

MASON
He's supposed to be my best friend?

Victoria nods.

MASON
Hopefully he'll grow on me.

INT. FILM CLASSROOM - DAY

Mason sits at his podium. He looks up at a clock: **10:42 AM.**

Looking at his script, Mason sees: **"10:30 - MASON ENTERS THE CLASSROOM. TAKE ATTENDANCE. PLAY VIDEO."**

He looks at the spot Mason occupied yesterday. It's empty.

Mason looks at the class of students for a beat. The students sit silently.

MASON
Has anybody seen Edward?

Mason looks around for another beat. A landline RINGS. Mason listens to the call.

MASON
(to phone)
Oh, so he's not -- alright. Do I just sit here or -- okay. Does it really matter if I still take attendance -

CLICK. Mason looks at the receiver. He puts it back. He slowly pulls out the attendance sheet and scans the room. He marks everybody present, including Edward. After a beat:

MASON
So, how's everybody like this class so far?

No response.

MASON
Don't be shy!

Mason points at a FEMALE STUDENT.

MASON
You! What's your name?

The student points at herself. Mason nods.

MASON
Yeah, you.

The student looks at her script packet.

FEMALE STUDENT
Uh - I'm Clarissa Brown.

MASON
Nice to meet you, Clarissa. What'd
you take away from yesterday's
lesson?

Clarissa looks down at her script.

CLARISSA
(hesitant)
I'm not sure.

Mason lets out a pained sigh.

MASON
Class, let's try to pay attention
today, alright?

Mason pulls out his computer, plugs it in, and plays another video. The AI-generated version of Mason drones on about camera angles as the real Mason stares at the screen, getting lost in his own thoughts for a moment.

SUDDENLY, the bell RINGS.

Mason looks at the video, which has turned off. He raises his eyebrows in concern. Turning his attention to the class, students flow out.

EXT. MASON'S HOME - NIGHT

Mason walks to the house. Taped to the front door is a note:
"@ Rowan's. Come over!"

Mason looks to his right and walks to the house.

EXT. ROWAN'S HOME - NIGHT

Mason knocks at the door. After a second, the door swings open.

ROWAN

What's up, Mason?! Thanks for
coming by!

Rowan bring Mason in for a hug. Mason reluctantly accepts.

INT. ROWAN'S HOME - NIGHT

Inside, Rowan's house is identical to Mason's. On the couch, Victoria is reviewing her script, but puts it away when Mason enters.

VICTORIA

Hi!

Mason waves. Rowan walks over to the couch. Mason follows.

ROWAN

We're just playing *Wii Party*, wanna
join us?

MASON

Wow, I haven't played that since I
was in elementary school! Sure,
I'll play!

VICTORIA

Swap in for me. I'm terrible.

Mason picks up a Wii-mote and plays with Rowan.

ROWAN

So Mason, tell me, what's your job
like?

MASON

It's weird, dude. That Edward guy
just straight up did not show up to
class today.

ROWAN

You should've seen the mess he
created today.

MASON

What happened?

ROWAN

He came into the store and
'accidentally' knocked over a tall
display of pickle jars.

VICTORIA

It was so crazy! You should've seen it.

MASON

Wait, you were there?

VICTORIA

Yeah. Today my job was to stand in the corner and look shocked when he knocked it over.

ROWAN

I'm telling you; dude's a weirdo. He actually pinned it on some random guy and got away with it.

MASON

Crazy.

Mason and Rowan silently play their game for a second. Mason loses.

MASON (CONT'D)

Damn! How'd you get so good?

ROWAN

I've been playing this every day since I got here a few months ago.

MASON

Months? How long are you here for?

ROWAN

Another two years, I think.

VICTORIA

Aren't you two supposed to be best friends? What are y'all's backstories?

ROWAN

A week ago or I read in my script that Thorin was my best friend from childhood back in Massachusetts, and he was transferring up after failing in the film industry.

MASON

Harsh. It's weirdly accurate, though.

ROWAN

Hey, you aren't failing now!

MASON
That's right.

Mason sets down his remote.

MASON (CONT'D)
Alright, it's time for us to head
out. Victoria?

Victoria looks up from her script.

VICTORIA
Oh! Alright.

MASON
Bye, Rowan!

ROWAN
Peace out, y'all.

Mason and Victoria step out of the house.

EXT. STREET - CONTINUOUS

As Mason and Victoria walk, Mason looks at her script.

MASON
You're so involved in memorizing
your script. What's up with that?

VICTORIA
Oh, I've got a big scene tomorrow.

MASON
Doing what?

VICTORIA
I'm going to lose a dog at a park
tomorrow, and Edward will save it.

MASON
What a modest guy. I don't think I
like him that much.

Victoria shrugs.

VICTORIA
He's giving us a job.

They reach their front door.

MASON
You're right.

INT. MASON'S HOME / BEDROOM - NIGHT

Mason sets his stuff on the counter and walks to the couch.

VICTORIA
Hey, I was thinking that we could
share the bed tonight? Get into
character and all.

Mason looks at his couch, thinking it over. He turns.

MASON
Uh...

A beat. Victoria eagerly awaits his answer.

MASON
Yeah. Why not?

Mason walks into the bedroom.

MASON
Wait, let me brush my teeth first!

He rushes into the bathroom and brushes his teeth. Victoria changes into pajamas and lies in bed.

Mason walks back into the bedroom and slips off his shoes and pants.

VICTORIA
No pajamas?

MASON
No.
(worried)
Is that a problem?

Victoria rolls her eyes playfully.

VICTORIA
You're ridiculous. Come to bed!

She pats a spot on the bed. Mason awkwardly walks over and gets under the covers. Victoria laughs. Mason and Victoria look at each other.

VICTORIA
Good night, Mace.

MASON
Night, Vicky-T.

VICTORIA
(laughs)
Absolutely not.

Mason smiles. Victoria smiles back. They turn on their opposite sides and go to bed.

MONTAGE - MASON'S JOB PROGRESSION

The next day, Mason arrives to class. Edward isn't there again. Mason writes: "New assignment: Film Analysis Essay" on the board.

After showing the daily video to the class, Mason calls on Clarissa, asking for her thoughts on the video. She's still unable to respond.

In the evening, Mason walks to the park to watch Victoria's big performance. She stands by a tree, wailing about her lost dog. Edward shows up and saves the day.

At night, Mason, Rowan, and Victoria hang out at Rowan's house.

Mason and Rowan engage in a round of *Wii Sports Resort* sword fighting. Rowan easily defeats him. Rowan celebrates goofily.

Later, Victoria and Mason sleep in the same bed, but face opposite directions.

In the morning, Mason and Victoria open the door to see large SCRIPTS for the following week.

The next day, Mason scans the room. Edward is present, but not paying attention.

While the video is playing for his class, Clarissa raises her hand. Mason pauses the video and answers her question.

At the end of class, students walk up and place essays on Mason's podium.

As they walk out, Mason has to walk up to Edward's seat and pick up his essay.

In the evening, Edward is at an ice cream parlor. He's stupidly underdressed for a date with a DROP-DEAD GORGEOUS WOMAN, much younger than he.

In the background, Mason and Victoria share an ice cream cone.

At night, Mason and Victoria sleep facing away from each other in bed. They turn to face each other at the same time, and embrace in a kiss.

Mason receives another week of scripts in the morning.

In class later, Mason smiles while grading essays from students. While a video is playing, he grades Clarissa's essay, and gives it an A+.

Once he gets to Edward's essay, he looks through it with a concerned look.

He looks at the script: **"GRADE EDWARD'S ESSAY - A+"**

He looks back at the essay. He gives it a **C-** and moves on.

Later, Victoria cheers on as Mason engages in a much closer round of sword fighting with Rowan on *Wii Sports Resort*.

Mason knocks Rowan's Mii off of a large podium, and is the winner! Mason celebrates, receiving a large kiss from Victoria.

Mason acts out sword fighting with his Wii-mote to Rowan. It's cute.

Back at their house, Mason and Victoria make out before closing their bedroom door.

END MONTAGE

INT. MASON'S HOME - MORNING

The next morning, Mason, with messy hair, walks to the front door in his underwear.

On the ground is a MUCH SMALLER RED SCRIPT, marked with "EMERGENCY CORRECTIONS" on it. He sets it on the counter and gets dressed.

Later, Victoria looks over the script while Mason walks into the kitchen.

VICTORIA
Mason, this isn't good.

MASON
What is it?

VICTORIA
Emergency corrections only come
when something bad happens.
(MORE)

VICTORIA (CONT'D)

This script says that you have a private meeting with Edward. Is that normal?

MASON

Definitely not. I haven't said a word to him yet.

VICTORIA

Why do you think you'd have one?

MASON

Not sure. I gave him a failing grade on an essay.

VICTORIA

Was that in the script?

MASON

No -- but it really was a terrible paper.

VICTORIA

If it's not in the script, you probably shouldn't have done that.

MASON

Yeah... I know. You're right.

VICTORIA

(trying to lighten the mood)

It should be fine, though! Let me know what happens!

MASON

Thanks, Vic. I've gotta go.

VICTORIA

Have a good day!

Victoria gives a quick kiss to Mason.

INT. CLASS - AFTERNOON

In class, students watch the end of a video. Mason sits at the podium.

AI-GENERATED MASON

...since the wealthy are largely responsible for financing filmmaking, it's important that you cater to them.

Mason raises his eyebrow. The video ends.

MASON

Alright, I guess that's the end!
I'll see you tomorrow, class!

STUDENTS

Thanks, Mr. Hornsby!

The students exit the classroom. Mason looks at his script:
**"EDWARD WILL ENTER AFTER CLASS AND DISCUSS FAILING GRADE YOU
GAVE HIM. YOU WILL FIX THE ISSUE. HE MIGHT ARGUE BACK AND
FORTH. APOLOGIZE."**

After the class is empty, the door opens. Edward, donning
sunglasses and earbuds, walks in. He slowly makes his way to
Mason.

EDWARD

Hello, Thorin.

MASON

(correcting him)
Mr. Hornsby. Hi, Edward.

EDWARD

(adamant)
Thorin.

Edward is a bit taken aback by this, but doesn't want a
fight.

MASON

(giving in)
Alright. Thorin. How can I help
you.

EDWARD

Yesterday, you gave me shit grade
on my paper.

Mason nods his head.

MASON

Yeah.

EDWARD

Why did you think you could do
that?

Mason thinks for a beat.

MASON

I -- I'm a bit confused. Why are you in this course again?

Edward looks defiant.

EDWARD

That's none of your concern, Thorin.

Mason has to refocus to prevent himself from getting upset.

MASON

Of course. I'm sorry. I'll fix it.

EDWARD

No.

MASON

I'm sorry?

EDWARD

I want to know why you gave me that grade.

Another beat. Mason doesn't want to say something he'll regret.

MASON

I graded your essay against the criteria I set out. Your critical analysis was surface level and -- did you write it yourself? It seemed like AI wrote it for you.

Edward angrily stares forward at Mason.

EDWARD

Change the grade.

MASON

(relenting)

Fine. I'll be changed.

Edward cracks a shit-eating grin.

EDWARD

Great. Come here.

Edward gestures Mason to lean forward, as if to whisper to him.

Mason leans forward. Edward pulls back and SLAPS MASON HARD. Mason quickly pulls back and rubs his face.

MASON

What the?!

EDWARD

Don't **fuck** with me. Do your job.

Edward turns around and walks out. Mason stands in shock.

INT. ROWAN'S HOME - NIGHT

Victoria and Rowan play *Mario Party 9* together on Rowan's Wii. Rowan easily defeats her. Their scripts are open in front of them.

VICTORIA

I'll get you one of these days.

ROWAN

Oh, I can't wait to see tha-

Mason BURSTS through the door. Victoria closes their scripts.

MASON

That little shit! That fucking bastard! I'm going to kill him, I swear to God.

Rowan quickly gets up and tries to calm Mason down.

ROWAN

Calm down, dude! Take a deep breath.

Rowan leads Mason through a guided deep breath. After a beat:

MASON

Edward. I gave him a bad grade on some exam - because he's a shitty writer - and he FUCKING SLAPPED ME!

VICTORIA

He what?

MASON

He assaulted me! I can't do this shit anymore. I'm leaving. This job isn't fucking worth it.

ROWAN

Woah! Wait, you can't leave now!

MASON

No, man, I have to. I'm getting assaulted on the job. I need to at least report this.

VICTORIA

I assume they've already been alerted. You won't have to report it.

MASON

What?

VICTORIA

They have cameras *everywhere*. They review all the footage and give it to Edward so he can save memories or whatever.

MASON

They're recording all of this? What the hell is this thing?

VICTORIA

Look, I have no idea, either. We just... have to deal with it.

Victoria puts her arms on Mason in an attempt to calm him down.

VICTORIA

I need you here with me. I've realized a lot about myself being with you over these last few months. Please, reconsider staying here.

Victoria's pleading gets to Mason. Mason groans after thinking hard.

MASON

I just -- this is not good for my mental health.

Rowan steps forward holding a letter.

ROWAN

This might help you reconsider.

Rowan hands it to Mason, who opens it up suspiciously.

MASON

(while opening)
What is this?

ROWAN
(playfully)
Just open it, asshole.

Mason scans through the contents of the letter: **"AFTER CAREFUL RECONSIDERATION... YOUR PAY WILL NOW BE \$10 MILLION, AN INCREASE OF \$5 MILLION OVER YOUR PREVIOUS CONTRACT."**

MASON
What the...?

VICTORIA
What is it?

MASON
They're doubling my pay. \$10 million.

ROWAN
No way.

Rowan looks at the letter.

ROWAN
No way!

Mason cautiously looks at Rowan and nods.

VICTORIA
\$10 million is a lot.

MASON
(exasperated)
I KNOW!

Mason takes a deep breath. A long beat.

MASON
You're right. I'll think it over.

Victoria smiles at this. Mason smiles faintly.

INT. MASON'S HOME - NIGHT / MORNING

In the bedroom, Mason gets into bed for the night. Victoria lies in bed next to him.

Mason turns to his side and looks uncertain of his future.

MASON
Victoria?

VICTORIA

Hm?

MASON

Never mind. Good night.

The next morning, Mason sits in the kitchen, scanning through the script for this week.

Victoria slides a plate of eggs for him to eat.

VICTORIA

Cheer up, Mase.

Mason cracks a faint smile.

MASON

Thanks.

Mason continues reading for a second.

MASON

I don't have any interactions with Edward this week.

VICTORIA

What's the point in going to work if the guy who the whole thing is about doesn't show up?

MASON

I'm not sure. The writing looks different this week, did the writers changed?

Victoria shrugs. Mason sighs. A beat.

MASON

Alright, I'm heading to work.

Victoria walks around the counter and gives Mason a kiss on the cheek.

VICTORIA

Have a good day!

INT. FILM CLASSROOM - DAY

Mason sits at the podium, scribbling on some scrap paper while the class sits forward.

A beat.

CLARISSA
(quietly)
Mr. Hornsby?

Mason doesn't look up. Clarissa clears her throat.

CLARISSA
(slightly louder)
Mr. Hornsby?

Mason looks up.

MASON
Oh, that's me! I almost forgot.

Mason laughs to himself. It's awkward.

MASON
How can I help you?

CLARISSA
What are we learning today?

MASON
Well --

Mason gestures to Edward's empty seat.

MASON (CONT'D)
Edward isn't here, so I figured I
wouldn't have to do anything today.

CLARISSA
Why does Edward determine whether
you teach us?

Mason looks confused.

MASON
What's that?

CLARISSA
I felt like we were learning a lot
even when Edward wasn't here.

MASON
Yeah, but aren't all of you actors?
What do you have to learn anyways?

The class looks forward with a confused look. A MALE STUDENT,
TRENT WILLIAMS (17) raises his hand. Mason points to him.

TRENT

I'm confused. Are we supposed to be actors?

Are they? Mason looks even more confused, but decides to roll with it.

MASON

I, uh, no? Um --

Mason looks around the room.

MASON (CONT'D)

Remember those videos I've been showing you over the last few weeks?

The class nods.

MASON (CONT'D)

That's bullshit. It's the same regurgitated nonsense from the front page of Wikipedia. If y'all are supposed to be learning, this isn't how it'll happen.

CLARISSA

Why don't you try to teach us without the videos?

Mason takes a deep breath.

MASON (CONT'D)

I'm not trained in teaching. I'm a failed actor. Trust me, you're the last man you'd want telling you how to live your lives.

(a beat)

Screw it. I'm getting paid too much to sit around.

Mason turns to the board and grabs a piece of chalk. He writes "**NEW ASSIGNMENT:**" before turning around and looking to the cast.

MASON

Any ideas?

Trent shrugs. Mason looks at Clarissa. She shrugs, too.

MASON

Do y'all's phones work?

Clarissa holds up her phone. It's a black screen. When she clicks on it, nothing happens.

MASON

No phones. Got it. How about this:
come up with a film idea and
present it tomorrow.

Mason writes "**PRESENT FILM IDEAS**" on the board.

MASON

I want something original! Get out
there and get creative!

The class looks excited. They file out. Mason smiles.

INT. BOWLING ALLEY - EVENING

Mason, Victoria, and Rowan sit in a LARGE BOWLING ALLEY.

In the lane next to them, A group of HOT WOMEN sit while Edward walks up to bowl.

Edward's form sucks. He tosses the ball, and as soon as it looks like it'll go into the gutter, it mysteriously REDIRECTS ITSELF into a STRIKE. He cheers.

Mason, Victoria, and Rowan loudly cheer and clap, but Mason, whose face is away from Edward, holds a straight face. Victoria and Rowan drop their smiles after.

Rowan reaches for a plate of tater tots. He bites into one, but spits it out.

ROWAN

(to self)
It's cold.

He looks at Edward's table. It's stacked with wings, pretzels, popcorn, pizza, and STEAMING TATER TOTS. All untouched.

MASON

I dare you to take one from over
there.

Rowan thinks about it for a second but decides against it.

ROWAN

Could you imagine? I'd probably get
killed off.

Mason assumes Rowan is joking.

MASON
That's awfully dramatic.

VICTORIA
(nonchalantly)
I heard Rachel's character was
getting killed, too.

MASON
Killed off? Huh?

VICTORIA
Whenever Edward deems a character
to have served their purpose, he
dramatically has their characters
murdered instead of just writing
them out.

MASON
What a weirdo.

The three lull to a silence. After a moment:

ROWAN
How's your job, Mase?

Mason jolts up at this.

MASON
Dude, it's so weird! Are any of the
people here normal besides Edward?
I can't tell if my students are
actors or if they were just messing
with me.

ROWAN
What happened?

MASON
Edward stopped showing up to class,
and unprompted, one of the kids
asks me why I wasn't teaching them
anything. They seemed confused when
I asked if they were acting.

VICTORIA
Maybe they just have to stay in
character?

MASON
Maybe? I don't know. Since Edward
doesn't show up to class anymore, I
figured I'll just teach them
without a script.

Victoria looks intrigued.

VICTORIA
Really? That's exciting.

ROWAN
I would not trust my kids with this
guy.

Mason playfully hits Rowan on the shoulder. They all laugh.

MONTAGE - MASON GETS BACK INTO A GROOVE

Mason stands at the front of the class. Students eagerly await a lesson.

Mason looks at his script: **"TEACH CLASS AS USUAL, EVEN WITHOUT THE PRESENCE OF EDWARD."** He nods to Clarissa, who walks up and presents her idea.

Multiple students talk in the front of the class, and Mason watches while writing down notes.

After class, he writes **"TOMORROW - FLESHING OUT YOUR FILM IDEAS"** on the board. Students come one by one to pick up his notes before leaving.

Later that night, Mason stands on a street corner while Rowan acts out a sequence for Edward in which Rowan DROPS HIS WALLET, then Edward graciously returns it.

In class the next day, Mason works one-on-one with Trent, who has a one-page summary of a film idea. He doesn't notice Edward's absence at this point.

In a park, Mason stands with Rowan while watching a MAN put on a SKI MASK while Victoria walks down a DIMLY LIT PATH.

The man runs up to Victoria with a gun. Victoria screams, Mason and Rowan laugh, but Edward saves the day by jumping out of a bush and punching the man in the gut.

Mason and Rowan, along with other ACTORS, applaud Ethan.

Later, Mason teaches screenplay formatting to students on a large whiteboard. The students eagerly take notes.

At home, Victoria looks over her script while Mason carefully looks through the screenplays submitted by his students. Victoria looks up from her papers and smiles.

INT. MASON'S HOME - MORNING

As Victoria and Mason eat breakfast together, the SCRIPTS are pushed through the MAIL SLOT. They're thicker than usual.

Victoria walks over and grabs their scripts. She hands Mason's over.

MASON

Woah, this is a lot busier than
this week.

Mason and Victoria exchange looks.

VICTORIA

Think we have a big role?

The two look excited at the prospect. They quickly flip through.

Mason flips through a script: **"TUESDAY...EDWARD WILL APPROACH AFTER CLASS...PROPOSITION YOU TO HAVE INTIMATE RELATIONS WITH RYAN...WEDNESDAY...LEAVE YOUR HOUSE TO GET GROCERIES AT 12:30 AND LEAVE THE DOOR OPEN"**

As he reads through, he looks increasingly concerned.

MASON

What the fuck?

VICTORIA

(while reading)

What's up?

MASON

Are you reading this?

Victoria looks a bit upset.

VICTORIA

Yeah. I'm going to have to wait
another week to get any sort of
development.

MASON

Not that.

Mason flips his script over.

MASON

It looks like Edward wants to have
sex with you.

VICTORIA
(concerned)
What the fuck?!

MASON
That's what I said. Why doesn't it
say it in your script?

Victoria flips through her script.

VICTORIA
When is this happening?

MASON
Wednesday at 12:30.

She finds the date and time.

VICTORIA
It says I'm just supposed to be at
home, cleaning for a party later.

The two exchange concerned looks.

MASON
Is he going to...?

VICTORIA
He better fucking not.

MASON
I won't let it happen. This is
insane. Who the hell wrote this?

VICTORIA
I mean, we know where the writers
work, right?

Good idea. Mason nods in understanding to Victoria.

INT. GROCERY STORE - NIGHT

Inside a WELL-STOCKED GROCERY STORE, Mason and Victoria stand
in a medicine aisle next to a well-stocked shopping cart.

The two look over their scripts for the week, nearing the end
of that weeks' pack.

MASON
Wait, so these aren't our actual
groceries?

VICTORIA
No, we get those from a separate
shipment.

An small alarm RINGS in the background. Mason quickly puts
his script away.

Other EXTRAS in the grocery store move into positions.

At the front of the store, the doors open.

Edward STRUTS in, looking around the store. An ASSISTANT,
AMBER, (female, 20s) follows him.

EDWARD
I want something... floral.
Something that says I'm a fun guy
who deserves to get the girl.

Amber quickly writes this down in a small note pad.

AMBER
(while writing)
Floral... fun... got it.

Edward walks down one of the rows. He sees an aisle full of
cereal and decides to make his way down.

While walking, he tears into a box of LUCKY CHARMS. He pours
a little bit into his mouth, and throws the box onto the
ground.

Amber follows him.

EDWARD
(chewing)
Can you get somebody to make Lucky
Charms, but just with the
marshmallows?

AMBER
I think they already make that.

EDWARD
Let's get somebody to do that. I
think it would be better.

AMBER
Alright.

Amber jots this down.

Edward makes his way into the medicine aisle.

VICTORIA
(quietly)
I'm going to have to act interested
in him here. Kill me.

MASON
Shh. You got this.

Edward walks down the aisle, looking at the full bottles of medicine. He opens a bottle and dumps some pills into his hand.

EDWARD
What's this one do?

AMBER
Uh, I'm not sure.

Amber grabs the bottle and looks at it.

AMBER
I think it's for depression.

EDWARD
Do I look like I need medication
for depression? Get rid of it.

Edward continues walking. Immediately after, a team of EXTRAS walk into the aisle and quickly toss all the bottles into shopping carts, disposing of them.

Mason and Victoria starts looking through the shelves.

MASON
(in character)
Babe, do you think that we'd need
any vitamin C?

VICTORIA
Babe, I'd get a multivitamin. It's
much better.

MASON
Thanks, babe.

Edward walks up to Victoria. He WHISTLES.

MASON
Well, hello! I take it you're
Thorin's wife?

Victoria turns around.

VICTORIA
(enthusiastically)
You would be correct! I'm Ryan
Hornsby. It's great to meet you.

Victoria goes in for a handshake, but Edward pulls her in for an uncomfortable hug.

Mason turns around.

MASON
Hello, Edward! This is my wife,
Ryan.

EDWARD
She's a real beautiful thing.

Mason nods. For an awkward beat, he checks Victoria out.

EDWARD
How is Thorin, sexually speaking?

Victoria cringes for a second, but puts on a brave face.

VICTORIA
Oh, he's great! I love having sex
with my husband.

EDWARD
I bet.

He continues to check her out. **What a creep.** Mason stands turned around.

EDWARD
(somewhat quietly, but not
nearly enough)
If you're free this week, would you
like to go out with me?

VICTORIA
Oh, I'm not sure. My husband might
not approve.

EDWARD
He definitely will. I can take good
care of you.

VICTORIA
When you put it that way, how could
I refuse?

Edward smiles and nods to Victoria, before walking off. Victoria smiles at him while he leaves. Once he's out of view, the two release their breaths and look at each other.

EDWARD
(checks around him;
silently)
What the hell?

VICTORIA
I know!

Victoria mockingly gags. A beat.

VICTORIA
I don't think I can do this, Mase.

Mason puts his arms on Victoria's shoulders.

MASON
Hold out for me. I promise
everything will be alright.

INT. FILM CLASSROOM - DAY

The next day, Mason walks into class a bit late. The students sit straight, like they did at the beginning.

MASON
(while walking)
Alright, y'all! I got finished
reading Trent's screenplay, which
means I can finally start giving
them ba-

Mason reaches the podium and turns around, seeing Edward in his chair.

MASON
(finishing thought)
Back.

Mason his back to the class and rolls his eyes.

MASON
(bored)
Change of plans. Let's watch a
video today.

Mason turns on one of those AI-generated videos from earlier. He ignores it while flipping through a screenplay he received from a student. He listens in after hearing:

AI-GENERATED MASON

One of the most important elements in screenwriting is writing a good protagonist. The protagonist of a story is the good guy. It's important that all of his goals are reached, no matter what gets in his way.

Mason sports a look of disgust on his face. The bell RINGS.

MASON

(under breath)

Already?

(to students)

I will see all of you tomorrow! Get on out of here.

The students pack up their stuff, looking a bit disappointed, before walking out of class.

After watching the students leave, Edward signals for Mason to walk over, which he reluctantly does.

EDWARD

Hi, Thorin.

MASON

Edward.

EDWARD

How are you?

Mason takes a deep breath.

MASON

(clearly hates him)

I'm fine, Edward. Thank you for asking. I've noticed you haven't been at school.

EDWARD

I've moved onto better things. Speaking of: I was thinking of moving onto that hot piece of ass you have. What's her name?

Mason plays dumb.

MASON

I don't know who you're talking about.

Edward scrunches up his face.

EDWARD

Yes, you do. Fucking tell me.

The sudden hostility makes Mason change his mind.

MASON

Victoria?

EDWARD

Yeah. She's fuckable, right?

Mason is visibly uncomfortable.

MASON

That's my wife you're talking about.

EDWARD

Marriage is a funny thing, Mason. My dad cheated on my mom multiple times while I was young. My mom cheated on her boyfriends many times throughout my life. What's wrong with a bit of cheating when everybody seems to engage in it?

Mason waits a second before responding.

MASON

That's a good point.

EDWARD

During class tomorrow, I'll be at your home. Don't come back.

Edward gets out of his desk and walks out of class, not making eye contact with Mason. Mason looks upset.

INT. BAR - NIGHT

In a SMALL BAR, Mason sits at the high top with Victoria and Rowan.

ROWAN

Got anything on tap?

The BARTENDER (60s) shakes his head no.

ROWAN

Are you even a real bartender?

BARTENDER

'afriad not. I make a mean can of
Busch Light, though.
(laughs to self)
Edward loves those.

VICTORIA

Of course he does.

The bartender places three cans of beer on the counter. The three pick them up and go to another table.

MASON

Let me tell you two: this dude is
probably jerking off to the thought
of cuckolding my "wife" tomorrow.

VICTORIA

(distressed)
I cannot deal with this tomorrow.
This creep is going to ruin my
life.

FINISH THIS SCENE AND WRITE A SHORT SCENE AT NIGHT WHERE
VICTORIA ASKS IF MASON'LL DO ANYTHING

INT. FILM CLASSROOM - DAY

Mason looks at his students. Edward isn't in class again. He checks the clock. Looking down at his script: **"EDWARD IS ABSENT FROM CLASS. IGNORE THIS."** He takes a deep breath.

CLARISSA

Is everything alright, Mr. Hornsby?

Mason turns his head to Clarissa. He puts on a happy face.

MASON

Oh, I was just thinking about who's
screenplay I wanted to give back
first. How about yours?

Mason looks at the stack of screenplays, ruffles through it, and hands Clarissa's back to hers. He holds onto it hard as she grabs it.

She gives a second tug and he releases. He stares off
distantly.

CLARISSA

Are you sure you're fine?

Mason looks at her. He looks to the door.

Without a word, Mason storms out of the classroom.

INT. MASON'S HOME - DAY

Mason runs up to the house and goes to the door. He hovers his hand over the door handle, but removes it and walks to the window. He peers in.

Victoria awkwardly stands in the kitchen, cooking up some eggs while Edward stretches himself on the couch, like he owns the place.

EDWARD

Once you're done with those eggs,
why don't you let me get at your
eggs?

Victoria faces away from him to hide her disgust. She looks down at her script and reads along.

VICTORIA

(forced)
Oh, whatever you want,
(even more forced)
daddy.

EDWARD

You've got my blood flowing now.

She looks up from her script and sees Edward standing out the window. She widens her eyes and gestures for him to come him.

EDWARD

What's the update on the eggs?

VICTORIA

Uh, they're coming right up!

She gestures for Mason to enter again.

Outside, Mason walks to the door and places his hand on the handle again. Now, he confidently opens the door.

MASON

Honey, I'm home!

Edward quickly whips his head around. His face is a mixture of shock and anger.

EDWARD

What are you doing here, Thorin?

Mason acts surprised to see Edward.

MASON

I figured I'd come home from work a bit early and surprise my wife. What are you here for?

EDWARD

That's none of your concern.

MASON

Actually, it's just my concern.

EDWARD

(sternly)

Go back to work. Now.

Victoria stands to the side, trying not to get involved.

MASON

(firmly)

No. I think it's time for you to leave.

Edward breaths heavily. He looks at Victoria, then back at Mason.

EDWARD

(shakily)

You -

He trails off. Mason looks at Edward, proud of himself.

EDWARD

(trying to look tough)

You will FUCKING regret this.

Edward storms out of the house. He slams the door, startling Victoria.

Mason quickly walks to Victoria and gives her a hug. She begins to sob, cracking under the pressure.

MASON

It's okay, I won't let him mess with you anymore.

Mason soothes Victoria for a bit. It works. Right on cue, a KNOCK.

Mason walks to the door, but Rowan enters before he can get the handle.

ROWAN

Dude, what the hell happened?

MASON

Edward was being a creep and tried
to have sex with Victoria.

ROWAN

(messing with her)
You didn't let him hit?

Victoria doesn't appreciate it.

MASON

(quiet and stern)
Dude, shut up.

Rowan raises his hands apologetically.

VICTORIA

I appreciate your concern, Rowan,
but could you leave us be?

Rowan shoots a look of concern at Victoria. She gestures for
him to leave. Mason doesn't notice this.

ROWAN

Alright, alright. I'm going.

He walks out. Mason turns to Victoria.

MASON

Let's get to bed. I'm feeling
tired.

Mason and Victoria walk to the bedroom.

The next morning, Victoria prepares breakfast for Mason.

Through the mail slot, two SCRIPTS are pushed through the
mail slot. One is significantly thinner than the other. Mason
walks to pick them up.

MASON

(looking at scripts)
Hm. My script for this week is
really short.
(jokingly)
You think I'm getting killed off?

VICTORIA

Don't joke like that.

Mason flips through the screenplay: **"IN THE EVENING...THORIN
APPROACHES A DARK HALLWAY...TWO SWIFT SHOTS IN THE ABDOMEN.
PAY REDUCED TO \$23,500"**

MASON
Holy shit. I wasn't joking.

VICTORIA
What's that?

MASON
I'm getting killed off.

Victoria stops cooking and quickly walks to him.

VICTORIA
What?!

MASON
I --
(seeing her concern)
That can't be right.

He flips through it again. He tosses it on the floor.

MASON
It's right. They're cutting my pay
to \$13,500. Nearly a year of work,
down the drain.

VICTORIA
When is this happening? Maybe we
can stop it.

MASON
(defeated)
It's tomorrow. I'm done.

Mason walks and sits on the couch. Victoria follows him. She crouches down and looks him in the eyes.

VICTORIA
Let's talk to the writers about
this. Maybe we can convince them to
let you stay.

Mason nods his head, accepting defeat. A beat.

MASON
I probably shouldn't have totally
changed up on the script.

Mason lets out a sad chuckle. Victoria smiles.

VICTORIA
You're a good person, don't ever
compromise on that. I appreciate
what you did for me.

He looks up at Victoria and smiles weakly. After a moment, he gets up from the couch.

MASON
I'm going to work?

VICTORIA
What? Why?

MASON
Script says so. Plus, I like these students a lot.

Mason grabs his bag and steps out the door.

INT. FILM CLASSROOM - DAY

Unlike previous days, the students don't simply stare forward. Instead, most of them look through the scripts that they received feedback on from Mason.

The silence of the room is broken by the sound of the door opening. Mason trudges in.

TRENT
Mr. Hornsby! Your feedback was great! I've retooled the third act to be more human sounding.

Mason silently nods. He places his bag on the podium and sits down.

At the back of the classroom, Mason sees Edward smugly smiling. He takes a deep breath.

In his bag, Mason retrieves the script for the day and reads from it.

MASON
(robotically)
Class, I regret to inform you that I, Thorin Hornsby, will be resigning from my post. I have been diagnosed with a threatening mental disorder that must be treated as soon as possible.
(under breath)
What does that even mean?

The students look disappointed. Clarissa raises her hand. Mason points to her.

CLARISSA
Today is your last class?

MASON
It seems like it.

CLARISSA
(disappointed)
Oh.

MASON
Look, guys. It's been an honor to teach y'all. This has been the ride of a lifetime. While I won't be able to teach you any more, I hope you can find some sort of meaning in this meaningless life. Your scripts all contain notes at the end of it expressing what your greatest qualities are. Play to those.

Mason looks to Edward.

MASON
I leave you with one piece of advice: the powerful will always try to take advantage of you. Don't let it happen.

The class sits in silence for a second. From somewhere in the room:

STUDENT #1
Thank you Mr. Hornsby!

STUDENT #2
We love you!

The students begin to cheer for him. Mason cracks a smile.

The bell RINGS.

INT. BAR - NIGHT

Mason sits at a bar with Victoria. The bar is mostly empty. Mason is a few beers deep already. He walks to the bartender.

He signals for another round. The bartender places two beers on the counter. Mason stumbles while bringing them back to the table with Victoria.

VICTORIA
You okay?

MASON
I'm -- yeah.

Victoria looks with a bit of concern to Mason.

VICTORIA
Look, I still want to be with you
when we leave this damn simulation.

MASON
You'll want me in two years? Yeah,
right.

Mason puts his head down on the bar and GROANS. He quickly
raises it and looks at Victoria.

MASON
(sudden energy)
Wait, where the hell is Rowan?

VICTORIA
Mase... I have some bad news.

Mason perks up.

VICTORIA
They decided to kill him off, too.

MASON
No fucking way. You're joking,
right?

Victoria shakes her head sadly.

MASON
Fuck it! Let's visit him! I want to
say goodbye to him before he
leaves.

VICTORIA
I'll let you do that. I don't wanna
get in the way of you two.

Mason hops out of his chair and walks out of the bar.

EXT. STREET - NIGHT

A dimly lit street. A light pattering of rain. Mason stumbles
through the street, mumbling to himself.

MASON

(quietly)

I've done more for this damn place
than anybody else has. Who could've
gotten those kids to actually care?
Nobody else could've. Me. I put in
that work.

The walk from the bar to Rowan's house isn't long.

EXT. ROWAN'S HOME - CONTINUOUS

Once at Rowan's house, Mason notices that his front door is
busted open. He looks around, but decides to peek through the
window instead of going inside.

While looking in, we see Rowan, kneeling on the ground with
his hands above his head. He's in tears, begging for his
life. His words are slightly muffled.

ROWAN

(a total wreck)

Please, you don't have to do this!
I have a family back home, I just
want to see them one last time!

Mason doesn't quite get the emotional state that Rowan is in.
He peeks around to see a few LARGE MEN in business suits.

As Rowan begs for his life, one of the business men quickly
pulls out a gun and **SHOOTS ROWAN IN THE HEAD! HOLY FUCK!**

Mason jumps from the window and quickly sprints to his house.
He fumbles with the door at first, but manages to get inside.

INT. MASON'S HOME - CONTINUOUS

Mason storms into the house, stumbling around in his panic.

MASON

(to self, quietly)

What the fuck? What the fuck?

(loudly)

What the fuck!?

He runs to his room and slams the door. He quickly runs to
the corner and kneels down.

Mason hyperventilates and holds himself tightly. The world
spins around him as he desperately tries to regain some sort
of sanity.

After a beat, everything is silent. Mason quietly at the room and begins to get up.

SUDDENLY, TWO KNOCKS. Then, THREE KNOCKS QUICKER.

Mason quickly gets down and hides.

The door slowly CREAKS open. Victoria peeks her head in. Mason looks from his hiding spot and sees her.

VICTORIA
(quietly)
Mase? Are you in here?

MASON
(quietly)
Shh! Get over here!

Victoria sees Mason and walks over to him. She holds something and places it on the bed as she walks in.

He gestures for her to get down with him.

VICTORIA
What are you doing down there?

MASON
(panicked)
They shot him! They fucking *shot*
him!

VICTORIA
(concerned)
Who?

MASON
Rowan! He's dead! They fucking SHOT
HIM!

Victoria looks to the bed for a second, then looks back at him. She gets down and comforts him.

VICTORIA
Take a deep breath.

After taking a breath, she continues.

VICTORIA
Okay -- what happened?

MASON

(through short breaths)

These guys -- I couldn't make out
who they were -- they were in these
big business suits -- I looked into
his window and saw Rowan kneeling
on the floor -- begging for his
life -- and they SHOT HIM!

Victoria pulls back for a second and glances at the bed
again. Mason notices, but doesn't say anything.

VICTORIA

Are you absolutely sure this wasn't
a trick? Like, you are certain it
was staged?

MASON

I mean... I've never seen somebody
get shot in the head!

(questioning)

I -- uh --

(confident)

No, this was definitely real.

VICTORIA

What the hell are we supposed to
do?

MASON

We've got to get out of here. How
can we leave the island?

VICTORIA

I -- uh...

Victoria loses her train of thought. Mason suddenly starts to
look concerned.

MASON

(concerned)

Victoria?

She continues to look at him, but steals a quick glance to
the bed. Mason looks over.

Seeing what she placed down, he jumps up and snatches a LARGE
SCRIPT, opened around the middle.

VICTORIA

Mason... wait! Give that back.

Mason walks to the other side of the room and looks between
the script and her.

MASON
What is this?

He looks down at the script. It's an extremely detailed page with notes for every possible action:

One line: **"FIND MASON IN THE HOUSE. IF HE'S ARMED, CALM HIM BEFORE DISARMING. YELL: "Mase, what the fuck is happening? Put the gun down!"**

Another: **"IF MASON DOESN'T REALIZE WHAT HAPPENED: "Mason, I just heard a gunshot, did you see what just happened?"**

He scans down the page and reads: **"IF MASON CAN'T CALM DOWN, CALM HIM DOWN: "Are you absolutely sure this wasn't a trick? Like you are certain it was staged?"**

MASON
Victoria... what the hell is this?

VICTORIA
It's not what it looks like!

He looks toward her with a look of betrayal.

MASON
Why does this say my name?

VICTORIA
(awkwardly)
I -- I've been writing a screenplay myself recently!

Mason shakes his head.

MASON
No, you haven't. You're not a good liar.

Victoria doesn't know what to say. Mason looks more distraught.

MASON
What the fuck is happening? Tell me that...
(yelling)
NOW!

Victoria jumps.

VICTORIA
(shakily)
It's nothing!

MASON
Stop lying to me!
(louder, voice breaking)
Stop lying to me Victoria.

Mason puts it together.

MASON
Is that -- is that even your name?

Victoria quickly nods her head.

VICTORIA
It is! I swear.

Mason looks down at the script.

A line: **"IF HE ASKS FOR YOUR REAL NAME: "It is! I swear."**

He looks back up at her and shakes his head.

MASON
(gesturing around)
All of this? This is for me?

Mason collapses to the ground, overwhelmed, and breaks into tears.

After a moment, the door SLAMS OPEN.

A dozen or so CREW MEMBERS, with cameras and lighting equipment file into the room.

The light blinds Mason, who quickly jumps up and gets into a defensive position.

The camera men get right into Mason's face, clearing the way for a woman. to step into the room.

It's Maxine.

Mason doesn't initially recognize her.

MAXINE
Hello, Mason Grant.

MASON
Who -- who are you?

MAXINE
You don't remember me?

Mason thinks about it for a second.

MASON
You're the lady in charge of this
whole thing, right?

MAXINE
That's right. Do you even know what
we do here?

Mason squints his eyes.

MAXINE (CONT'D)
I can see you're a bit overwhelmed.
Let me explain. Wave "hi!" to the
cameras. You're the star of a new
reality TV show!

MASON
What?

MAXINE
You're about to be a household
name. At the turn of the millenium,
52 million people watched the
finale of *Survivor*. No show has
been able to replicate that
success. We will.

Mason is putting the pieces together, and looks more
confident.

MASON
This isn't legal.

Maxine scoffs.

MAXINE
Legal? Read the contract you
signed.

Maxine pulls out a contract, signed by Mason. Mason grabs it
and looks through it.

The contract is identical to an attendance sheet from
earlier, with writing in between the lines that Mason didn't
notice.

MASON
Oh, fuck off. You tricked me.

Mason shoots a look over at Victoria, who cowers in a corner.
He shakes his head.

MAXINE
Would you like some answers, Mason?

Mason doesn't look up. He still stares at Victoria.

MAXINE (CONT'D)

You're familiar with Edward. While he was posed as the subject of this, he was actually designing this whole thing to be for you!

Mason looks up at Maxine with a scowl.

MAXINE

You see, Edward grew up an unusually tough upbringing. His classmates bullied him, parents abandoned him, robbing him of his childhood. After a wealthy inheritance gave him the resources to live the life he wanted -

MASON

Shut up.

Mason pushes through the cameras and runs out of the house.

EXT. WARREN ISLAND - NIGHT

We follow him through the perspective of the camera men as Mason runs through the town.

Dozens of extras stand outside of their homes, watching on.

Not far off, a LARGE MANSION sits atop a hill. Mason jogs over to it.

The front of the mansion stands considerably higher than Mason. He looks to the handle, but glances at a large window next to the door.

Mason walks to the window, grabs a rock sitting below it, and SMASHES the window in.

INT. EDWARD'S MANSION - NIGHT

Hopping into the house, Mason takes a look inside the mansion.

Dozens of photos of Edward adorn the walls. Many of these photos are clearly Photoshopped, removing his family from some photos and adding in celebrities for the others.

A fireplace is crackling. Above it, a GUN, looking straight out of the wild west. Mason looks at it as he walks through.

EXT. EDWARD'S MANSION - NIGHT

The camera crew arrives at the house, out of breath. Maxine arrives on a golf cart.

CAMERAMAN
Do we break in?

MAXINE
No. Let's see what happens.

Maxine pulls out a tablet, which displays a few cameras within the mansion.

INT. EDWARD'S MANSION - NIGHT

Mason makes his way to a large set of stairs.

As he ascends, we see digital frames along the wall, each displaying a different camera located around the island.

At the top of the stairs, large doors sit at the center.

Mason walks in.

An ENORMOUS CIRCULAR ROOM with hundreds of TV screens. Mason's face is a mix of awe, anger, and fear.

Sitting at a large desk is Edward.

EDWARD
Welcome to my humble abode, Mr. Hornsby. Or should I say -

MASON
Don't.

Edward puts on a smile.

EDWARD
I knew you'd bring the color to the screen!

Mason flips a tablet around to reveal a camera located inside the desk, pointed straight at Mason, now holding a straight face.

MASON
Why?

EDWARD
Why, what?

MASON
Shut the hell up, you arrogant
dick. Why did you do this?

Edward sighs.

EDWARD
I've been looking for a way to
showcase the human experience of
which I've lived. One of torment,
one where no matter what happens, I
can't truly be in control. You and
me aren't so different.

Mason raises his eyebrows. *Really?* He gives a profound eye
roll.

EDWARD
It's fine if you don't accept it.
It's all apart of the process.

MASON
Process?

EDWARD
Oh, you don't know?

Edward sits for a second. It doesn't look like he has more to
say.

MASON
(impatient)
Know what?

EDWARD
You're going to be everywhere! An
overnight celebrity, I say.

MASON
Yeah. Your assistant told me that.

EDWARD
Maxine?
(hurt)
That **bitch**. She always does this.

MASON
What's the point?

EDWARD
In what?

MASON
In me. Why would you choose me?

Edward gestures to the tablet.

EDWARD

Look at you!

Mason looks at himself. He's visibly tired, angry, as if he's been awake for a year.

MASON

What about it?

EDWARD

You're so...

(closes eyes to visualize)

Pathetic.

(laughs)

I mean -- everything you do turns to shit. You're a fucking terrible actor, Mason.

Mason holds back his frustration.

EDWARD

Our world is so obsessed with taking ordinary people and elevating them to become Gods. You'll be so famous with this show, everybody will know your name. I can't wait to see how everybody chooses to judge you without knowing a thing! Twitter will be ablaze with debates over if you're horrible person or not. And who's to say, anyways? Maybe you are! Maybe we have a clip of you talking about a sex crime you got away with.

Edward swipes to reveal the AI-generated Mason groping an unsuspecting woman.

EDWARD (CONT'D)

That's the fun of it all! This world was so quick to judge me. Now you'll have to feel what I felt.

MASON

(flustered)

So... that's it? You've already ruined my shitty life and now you're planning on making it even worse?

Edward nods his head happily. Mason turns around and storms out. Edward gets out of his chair and follows him down.

Mason heads to the front door, only to find that it's locked.

EDWARD

There's no point in leaving yet! We
still have a final scene to film.

Mason doesn't want to know what it is. He walks to the living room.

EDWARD

I know it's a lot to take in. Don't
worry! We're almost at the end.

Quickly searching the room for something, Mason notices the gun from earlier. He picks it up.

EDWARD

Wanna shoot me? Go ahead. It'll
make for great TV.

Without a second thought, Mason pulls the trigger.

EXT. EDWARD'S MANSION - NIGHT

BAM!

The camera crew jumps, startled by the sound.

INT. EDWARD'S MANSION - NIGHT

Edward's legs stand strong, but buckle slightly after a second.

His body CAREENS to the floor. Blood spurts from his head. His face, a slight smile.

Over the pictures, blood drips from the splatter.

Mason stoically holds the gun.

The front door BURSTS OPEN.

The camera crew, with lights blaring push in on Mason.

Maxine follows in a panic. She runs in front of the cameras and kneels over Edward.

MAXINE
(hysterical)
WHAT THE FUCK?! WHAT THE HELL HAVE
YOU DONE?!

Maxine begins to sob. After a moment, she stops. Turning to the camera:

MAXINE
(normal)
Did you get that?

For the first time since the shot, Mason's facial expression turns to concern.

MASON
What?

Maxine turns to Mason and gives him a big kiss. He tries to get her away.

MAXINE
Mason! You've done it.

Mason raises an eyebrow.

MAXINE
I mean, originally this was going
to end with you burning the house
down in a fit of rage but this --

Maxine gestures around the house. A bit more blood spurts out of Edward's head.

MAXINE
This is better than anything we
could've came up with. What do you
have to say?

The cameras push in on Mason further. He looks at the gun in his hand and drops it. Staring right into the camera:

MASON
(direct)
Fuck your show.

BEGIN MONTAGE - ENTERTAINMENT BROADCAST

We pull out from Mason's final words to reveal a clip from Twitter.

The clip is attached to text: "An EXPLOSIVE finale from #WarrenIslandS1. What's next on the island?" The Tweet was sent from a brand account for the show.

With thousands of likes, somebody scrolls through a series of Tweets.

Most Tweets express love for the show. Some have playful GIFs of Mason with Victoria, Rowan, or his students. Some show his rage before the final confrontation, or steamier clips of Mason making out with Victoria.

A few express concern: "How is this dude not in prison? wtf?" or "mason is a total freak. everything he does is a major red flag."

Behind the screen, we hear Mason CHUCKLE. He likes the mean Tweets.

He scrolls down to an interview of Maxine. She's credited as the creator/lead writer of Warren Island.

MAXINE

Mason has proven to be an
unstoppable force. America loves
him.

INTERVIEWER

Can we expect more from him,
possibly in a second season?

Maxine looks into the camera.

MAXINE

He's out there, that's up to him
now. We'd love to get him back.

A slow zoom on this, as Mason thinks about it. The mouse HOVERS over the comment button.

INT. MASON'S APARTMENT - DAY

The laptop slams shut. On cue: a DOUBLE KNOCK, followed by a quick TRIPLE KNOCK.

Mason suspiciously looks to the door. Noah enters, carrying a large bag of groceries. A wave of relief.

MASON

Dude, stop doing that.

NOAH
C'mon! Can't you let a guy have a
bit of fun?

Noah sets the groceries down and begins to unpack them. It's
good party food.

On seeing Mason's look of general sadness.

NOAH
What's wrong?

Mason contemplates something.

MASON
I'm not sure. Now that the show's
over, what am I supposed to do now?

NOAH
Nothing. You've made it, dude.

Mason smiles.

NOAH
Oh, by the way, I invited Greg
over.

MASON
Greg? Why?

Greg enters the apartment. Mason tries to put on a happy face
and walks to greet him.

MASON
(fake excitement)
Greg! What's up?!

GREG
Mason! It's great to see you!

NOAH
While you two catch up, I have a
surprise for you, Mason!

Noah walks into the bedroom and carries out a large box. He
places it carefully on the table in the living room. Removing
the top of the box, he reveals the Monopoly board from
earlier, preserved exactly as it was.

This board brings Mason back to a simpler time.

MASON
Woah.

NOAH
Just like before. I haven't changed
a thing. Wanna play?

Mason looks at the board. He sees his piece stuck in jail.

MASON
Can I at least get out of jail?

NOAH
(laughs)
Hell no. Roll doubles first,
asshole.

The three of them laugh. They go back to playing the game.

On the TV, a special look back at the series is airing. We see the moment that Mason arrived in his home for the first time.

Mason looks at the TV, longingly.

While Greg rolls the dice, Noah notices Mason staring off. He looks at the TV, walks up, and turns it off.

This snaps Mason out of it.

The three go back to playing Monopoly.

We slowly pull out of the apartment, looking at the organized chaos of it all.

In the corner, a security camera films Mason.

Mason is happy.

CUT TO BLACK.

TITLE: **"MAIN CHARACTER SYNDROME"**